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PRATAP

GOING UP IN FLAMES





A MAJOR WORRY FOR EV OWNERS IS THE RISK OF THE BATTERY CATCHING FIRE. WITH RECENT REPORTS OF SOME ELECTRIC SCOOTERS COMBUSTING, THIS PROBLEM IS NOW FRONT AND CENTRE

In my 25 years as an automotive journalist, there have been a couple of products that have been described as revolutionary. The first was one that set out to offer two-wheeler buyers and owners a safer and more comfortable mode of transport—sparking fears that the existing infrastructure would not be able to cope with the coming deluge of this proletarian four wheeler. It didn't happen. Despite starting with a production capacity of 250,000 cars per year, production delays and perception problems meant sales did not touch even half that number—monthly sales peaked at about 10,000 cars. Then multiple reports of this car catching fire were the final nail in the coffin of this first mobility revolution as prospective buyers became reluctant to abandon their bikes and scooters for this attractively priced car.

Though vehicle fires are not very rare worldwide, with data in the US suggesting a few years ago that over 10 per cent of all reported fires in that country happened in vehicles, fires in electric vehicles are a totally different kettle of fish. Not only do they burn more fiercely, with temperatures going up much higher, they are also extremely difficult to put out and have a tendency to re-ignite even when they seem to have been put out completely. I have heard instances of the fire having been put out completely, the burnt-out vehicle transported to a yard for inspection and then catching fire again after many hours. Even the best of electric vehicles are not spared from this phenomenon, but EV fires are extremely rare. Although there is not enough data to comment specifically about them, and battery technology is also rapidly changing, the incidence of EV fires is very low. There have been some hyped-up instances of Tesla cars and GM's Bolt EV catching fire, but these are very few and far between. In fact, a study over an eight-year period shows that there were less than 10 Tesla cars catch-

WITH REPORTS OF POTENTIALLY GAME-CHANGING SCOOTERS CATCHING FIRE, THE FEAR IS THE GREEN MOBILITY REVOLUTION MAY COME TO A HALT